1.2 MATTHEW ARNOLD: LIFE AND WORKS

LIFE:

Matthew Arnold (1822-88) had an excellent education at one of the finest public schools in England, Rugby, where his father Dr. Arnold was headmaster. From there Arnold went up to Oxford, one of the oldest and most prestigious universities in England, where he also taught classics for two years. He was later appointed inspector of schools—a position he held for 35 years. In 1857, he was made Oxford Professor of Poetry and he continued in this appointment for 10 years. Arnold continued to write poetry till he was 45 years and then devoted most of his time to prose. He wrote prose of social criticism and tried to highlight the flaws of England's social and political structure. He believed that English society was made up of the Barbarians, the Philistines and the Populace. The Barbarians were the aristocracy who were totally insular to new ideas, the Philistines or the middle class was marked by vulgarity and dullness while the populace or the lower orders cared merely for food, beer and gin. Arnold hoped that the Middle Class would open its mind to culture which he defined as 'the knowledge of the best that has been thought and said in the world.'

WORKS

The Strayed Reveller and Other Poems	(1849)
Empodocles on Etna and Other Poems	(1852)
Poems. A New Edition. (Including 'Sohrab and Rustum')	(1853)
*Poems. Second Series (*Selections from 2 earlier vols. with 'Balder Dead')	(1854)
Merope	(1857)
England and the Italian Question	(1859)
On Translating Homer	(1861)
The Popular Education of France	(1861)
On Translating Homer : Last Words	(1862)
A French Eton	(1864)
Essays in Criticism : First Series (1865)	(1865)
On the Study of Celtic Literature , (1867)	(1867)
New Poems (restoring 'Empedocles on Etna')	(1867)
Culture and Anarchy	(1869)
Literature and Dogma	(1873)
Essays in Criticism : Second Series	(1888)

(Published posthumously)

1.3 'SHAKESPEARE'

You may be aware that there are two different kinds of sonnets—Petrarchan and Shakespearean. A Petrarchan sonnet is organized in two parts—an octet (8 lines) and a sestet (6 lines). One thought continues for the first eight lines and changes in the final sestet. A Shakespearean sonnet has 3 quatrains (4-line stanzas) and is rounded off by a couplet (2 lines). In this sonnet you will notice that the arrangement is different from these two kinds.

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